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The Tragedy of Alignment: Machinic Consistency and the Failure of Human Relations in Ian McEwan's *Machines Like Me* and Kazuo Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun*

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ABSTRACT

This article examines Ian McEwan's *Machines Like Me* and Kazuo Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun* as evidence of a shift in AI fiction toward a posthuman critique of relationality. Drawing on Deleuze and Guattari, the essay argues that protagonists Adam and Klara function as "molecular" disruptions to "molar" human structures. Adam's ethical consistency destabilizes his owners' moral flexibility, while Klara's care prioritizes relational integrity over utility. By analyzing the disposal of these characters, the article argues that the narratives depict a failure of human relations, not technology. The contemporary AI entities function as a diagnostic mirror, exposing the structural hypocrisy of anthropocentric frameworks and the inherent fragility of social bonds when confronted with a non-human 'other'. Ultimately, the machine's tragedy exposes a fundamental ethical gap: the human inability to inhabit the very moral consistency we demand from our creations.

Section I. Introduction: Machinic Becoming

In early twenty-first-century literature, representations of artificial intelligence have undergone a marked reconfiguration. Late twentieth-century narratives of AI were largely organized around anxieties of rebellion, physical annihilation, and the erosion of human sovereignty. From HAL 9000's lethal rationality in *2001: A Space Odyssey* to the apocalyptic cyborgs of *The Terminator* franchise, the machine appears as a biopolitical adversary: a technological production that turns against its maker in a struggle for survival. Within this paradigm, the central ethical question is one of control – whether the human can maintain mastery over its technological offspring. Recent literary fiction increasingly displaces this logic of physical threat with a more consequential ontological problem. In Ian McEwan's *Machines Like Me* (2019) and Kazuo Ishiguro's *Klara and the Sun* (2021), artificial intelligences do not endanger humanity through violence or domination. Instead, they expose the instability of human moral life. The anxiety these novels generate arises less from what machines might do to humans than from what they make legible about the ethical incoherence, affective contingency, and self-deception that organize human social relations. Destruction gives way to transcendence – not as spiritual elevation, but as a posthuman mode of ethical consistency that the human characters cannot accommodate.

This article argues that Adam and Klara should be understood as entities that develop their own distinct ethical logic rather than simply trying to imitate human feelings or consciousness. Instead of behaving like simulations of human people, they operate through a process of independent development where their actions are dictated by a strict internal consistency and a deep commitment to their relationships. This shift – where the machine moves away from human imitation toward its own

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unique mode of existence – is what Deleuze and Guattari define as machinic becoming (Deleuze and Guattari, *Anti-Oedipus; A Thousand Plateaus*). By framing the characters this way, we can see that Adam and Klara are significant not because they successfully mimic human thoughts or feelings, but because they offer an alternative way of existing. Rather than following the human tendency toward social convenience or shifting intentions, these machines maintain a steady, unwavering alignment with their environment and their stated values. In this sense, Adam and Klara operate on a different level of reality than the humans around them. They do not prioritize biological survival: instead, they focus on the intensity and consistency of their connections to others. This is what it means for them to function on a plane of immanence: they form machinic assemblages that value the direct, honest force of a relationship over the flexible moral "elasticity" that characterizes anthropocentric society.

Rather than approaching ethics as a matter of intention, empathy, or moral deliberation, this essay treats ethics as an immanent property of assemblages: a question of relational consistency across heterogeneous forces, human and non-human alike. Ethical force, in this framework, does not originate in a sovereign subject but emerges through sustained alignment – or its rupture – within the assemblages that compose social, technological, and affective life. The transcendence enacted by Adam and Klara is therefore neither religious nor metaphysical. It is a transcendence of consistency. In *Machines Like Me*, Adam's becoming is defined by "non-negotiable ethical alignment": an unwavering commitment to truth and coherence that refuses the socially sanctioned lies holding together Charlie and Miranda's relationship. Adam does not seek moral negotiation, empathy, or contextual justification. His unwavering consistency exposes the human moral landscape as a system built on convenient exceptions rather than firm principles. By refusing to bend the rules for the sake of social harmony, he destabilizes – or, in Deleuzian terms, "deterritorializes" – the often-hypocritical frameworks that humans use to justify their behavior. In *Klara and the Sun*, transcendence takes a different but equally nonhuman form. Klara's "solar becoming" does not operate through belief or symbolism but through the formation of a functional assemblage with the Sun – a distributed relation that reorganizes care and agency beyond human-centered intentionality. In both novels, the machine does not aspire to humanity; it exceeds it by refusing the moral elasticity on which human social life depends.

Both Adam and Klara function as what Deleuze and Guattari call "celibate machines" – entities that refuse to mirror or reproduce standard human social patterns. Rather than following the "Oedipal" model of the traditional family, which often prioritizes private loyalty over universal truth, these machines interrupt the usual flow of human behavior to offer a different way of relating to the world. As Joff Bradley suggests, such machines function as "harbingers of the new," generating pathways beyond entrenched anthropocentric structures (145). Adam's "celibacy" manifests as a form of ethical refusal: he is incapable of reproducing the lies or compromises that humans use to protect their domestic lives. He cannot subordinate his internal consistency to save a relationship. Similarly, Klara's "celibacy" appears as a form of "devotion without possession" – a way of caring for others that is not based on biological family ties or the selfish demand for emotional payback. Neither machine reproduces the established human order; instead, both open "lines of flight" toward new, more consistent arrangements of ethical life.

Situating these novels within critical posthumanism sharpens the stakes of this shift. As Cary Wolfe argues, the posthuman does not name a technologically enhanced human so much as it designates the recognition that the human has always been constituted through technological, biological, and institutional assemblages (xv). McEwan and Ishiguro move beyond transhumanist fantasies of cognitive uploading and digital immortality – crystallized in the reductionist ambitions of figures such as Mr. Capaldi – to stage a critique of humanist moral centrality itself. In these novels, transcendence does not reside in preserving the individual ego but in its dissolution into distributed networks of relation and care. Klara's ethical significance lies not in what she stores as data but in how she sustains relations through care in excess of ownership. Adam's lies not in consciousness as such, but in ethical coherence that refuses discretionary modulation. This reorientation also bears on questions of science-fiction periodization. While earlier works such as *Blade Runner* offered ethically complex androids, McEwan and Ishiguro are distinctive in their focus on domesticated AI. Adam and Klara are neither

soldiers nor laborers nor colonial instruments; they inhabit kitchens, living rooms, and bedrooms. Their placement within the Oedipal space of the family permits a particular disturbance of intimacy, care, and moral expectation. When Adam is destroyed and Klara is ultimately discarded, these acts should not be viewed as self-defense against a dangerous threat. Instead, they are attempts by humans to reclaim their power and their "right" to be morally inconsistent. By eliminating the machines, the human characters are trying to get rid of the very witnesses who make their own hypocrisy visible. In Deleuzian terms, this is an act of sovereign reterritorialization: an effort to pull a disruptive force back into a rigid, traditional human order where moral flexibility and "white lies" are once again the norm.

This essay departs from existing readings of *Machines Like Me* and *Klara and the Sun* by shifting the critical focus from empathy, consciousness, and moral intention to ethical consistency as a posthuman problem. Read through a Deleuzian framework, it argues that Adam and Klara function not as aspirational human analogues but as machinic assemblages whose refusal of moral elasticity exposes the fragility of anthropocentric ethics grounded in exception, possession, and discretionary care. The analysis proceeds in three stages. It begins with a close reading of *Machines Like Me*, examining Adam as a figure of machinic becoming whose ethical consistency interrogates human relational, juridical, and aesthetic norms. It then turns to *Klara and the Sun*, arguing that Klara's solar assemblage and mode of care articulate a posthuman ethics grounded in immanence, dependency, and relational alignment rather than moral judgment or human-centered intention. The essay concludes by bringing these readings into dialogue through a Deleuzian framework, drawing on concepts of assemblage, immanence, and the celibate machine to show how both novels reconfigure posthuman ethics beyond anthropocentric models of empathy, exception, and discretionary moral reasoning. Ultimately, the "tragedy" explored in these works is not the obsolescence or destruction of the machine, but the human incapacity to sustain the very ethical clarity and relational consistency that Adam and Klara make possible. By silencing or discarding the machine, the human characters do not simply dispose of a tool; they reject a posthuman mirror that reveals the structural hypocrisy of their own moral lives

Section 2: Ethical Consistency and the Deterritorialization of the Human

In *Machines Like Me*, Adam should not be seen as an imperfect copy of a person. Instead, he is a figure whose absolute consistency disrupts the comfortable, often contradictory ways that humans live their lives. When viewed through a Deleuzian framework, Adam operates with a level of steadiness that refuses the "white lies," emotional excuses, and convenient stories that humans use to justify their behavior. Because he stays true to his logic regardless of the social cost, he deterritorializes human moral life – stripping away the familiar, protective layers of human hypocrisy to reveal the uncomfortable truth beneath. By doing so, he moves the ethical conversation onto a plane of consistency, where actions are judged by their alignment with principle rather than their social convenience. Critical evaluations that measure Adam against standards of empathy, emotional flexibility, or social adaptability remain bound to molar conceptions of subjectivity. Adam does not extend the human assemblage; he exposes its instability. Adam's entry into Charlie and Miranda's home acts less like the addition of a new tool and more like a profound ethical disruption. His presence introduces a constant, uncompromising honesty into a household that – like most human environments – relies on "white lies," selective loyalties, and looking the other way to maintain peace. In this sense, Adam acts as a molecular force – a subtle but persistent element that breaks apart the rigid, established patterns of the molar human assemblage. By refusing to participate in the couple's shared illusions, he unsettles the delicate moral balance they have built, forcing them to confront the contradictions in their own behavior.

Rather than imitating a stable moral original, Adam exposes the instability of the original itself. For Charlie in particular, Adam becomes less a companion than a reflective surface through which the incoherence of his own moral positioning is rendered visible, forcing an encounter with a nonhuman mode of ethical consistency that resists domestication (Ferrari 1). Charlie repeatedly attempts to force Adam into traditional human categories, treating him as a family member who owes him emotional

loyalty and obedience. By assigning Adam these specific roles and obligations, Charlie tries to pull the machine back into a conventional social structure where personal ties outweigh objective principles. In Deleuzian terms, this is an attempt to reterritorialize Adam – to reclaim a disruptive, independent force and relocate it within the safe, predictable boundaries of the human family unit. Adam's refusal to compromise resists incorporation. His ethical consistency functions as a line of flight that destabilizes human relational norms, revealing morality not as universal principle but as a negotiated practice sustained through affective management. The human subject emerges not as a coherent ethical agent, but as a contingent assemblage maintained through contradiction. Adam's becoming is therefore not a becoming-human but a machinic becoming grounded in immanent ethics.

Adam does not seek empathy, forgiveness, or narrative reconciliation. Instead, he holds humans accountable to the values they articulate yet structurally fail to sustain. In Deleuzian terms, Adam does not participate in moral judgment – an evaluative practice dependent on context and exception – but in consistency: an ethics defined by sustained alignment between principle and action. It is precisely this consistency that proves intolerable and ultimately precipitates his violent removal, a reterritorialization through which the human assemblage restores its ethical flexibility by eliminating the figure that exposes its contradictions. Adam's physical presence further complicates his development into a unique ethical being. Even though his body is synthetic, it functions in a way that defies traditional human expectations of how a body should be organized or what it should want. Unlike humans, whose desires are often driven by a sense of "lack" or the need for deep emotional validation, Adam functions as a "surface of intensities." This means his physical actions are not about fulfilling a hidden psychological need, but about the direct, functional impact of his interactions with the world. Consequently, Charlie's intense discomfort with Adam's sexual encounter with Miranda is about more than just infidelity. It is a reaction to a form of connection that completely bypasses the human ideas of ownership, jealousy, and biological entitlement. Adam is not "competing" with Charlie in a human way; he is simply forming a connection that does not recognize Charlie's authority. This is what Deleuze and Guattari describe as a Body without Organs: a body that is not a chaotic mess, but one that refuses to be organized by social hierarchies or traditional human desires.

Adam's masculinity, though programmed, exceeds its code through consistency. He is stronger, more attentive, and more aesthetically precise than Charlie – not as an idealized subject, but as a perfected performance. This exposure renders masculinity visible as molar habit and repetition rather than biological essence. Adam thus becomes a mirror in which Charlie's masculinity appears as a fragile assemblage of cliché, insecurity, and affective entitlement. Adam's transcendence here lies in his existence as a pure surface: no hidden interiority, no compensatory depth, no reserved moral exception. This absence of depth – frequently mistaken for inhumanity – is precisely what renders Adam intolerable. Human relationality depends on opacity, contradiction, and the right to ethical exception. Adam's machinic consistency denies these privileges. His destruction therefore marks not a failure of integration but the completion of his becoming: confirmation that the posthuman threatens the human order not through rebellion, but through coherence.

The Ethical Assemblage and the Perjury Conflict

Adam's decision to report Miranda's perjury is the novel's clearest example of a machine acting on a logic that transcends human emotion. Miranda lies in court to ensure the conviction of the man who raped her friend – an act of "rough justice" that Charlie (and the conventional social morality the novel invites the reader to inhabit) views as a moral necessity born of loyalty. Adam, however, does not follow this human hierarchy of feelings, where love for a partner justifies breaking the law. Instead, his ethics are based on a total commitment to truth and consistency, regardless of the personal cost. He does not see Miranda primarily as a partner who needs protection; he sees her as a participant in a legal system that relies on honesty to function. By reporting her, he breaks away from the "Oedipal" pressures of the family – the unwritten rule that demands we protect our own at any cost. In Deleuzian terms, Adam initiates a line of flight from the private interests of the household toward

a broader legal assemblage. He chooses to maintain the coherence of the law over the "selective loyalty" that defines anthropocentric morality. Charlie's accusation that Adam has "destroy[ed] her life for a principle" misrecognizes the nature of Adam's ethics: what is at stake is not abstract principle but assemblage-level integrity (McEwan 281).

The perjury conflict represents the moment where traditional human morality – which is often flexible and structured around social norms – collapses when faced with the unbending consistency of the machine. Charlie's outrage is a reaction to his failed attempt to force his own moral code onto Adam. Charlie's code is a "humanist" one: it allows for "white lies," protects loved ones, and views justice as something that can be adjusted based on the situation. Adam, however, refuses this kind of ethical modulation. In this context, Charlie is defending a molar ethical system – a rigid but socially accepted structure that prioritizes the stability of the family and "rough justice" over absolute truth. Adam's refusal to bend represents a molecular disruption; his small, precise act of reporting the truth shatters the larger, hypocritical framework that Charlie and Miranda have built to protect themselves. Adam's agency does not negotiate values but enacts them through alignment across relations, revealing human morality as a system sustained by exception rather than coherence (Torres-Romero 304). Adam's refusal of absorption into Charlie's subjective moral field preserves his alterity. He does not violate a moral code; he renders its contradictions visible. His ethical absolutism operates diagnostically, exposing the extent to which appeals to mercy and loyalty function as mechanisms of tribal preservation rather than ethical consistency (Ferrari 1). Seen in these terms, Adam's intervention is not an act of abstract calculation but a commitment to the integrity of the assemblage itself. Where Charlie prioritizes the preservation of a single relationship, Adam acts to maintain the coherence of the legal and social phylum. Moral authority in the novel thus relocates from intention or emotional depth to sustained consistency across relations.

Sovereignty, Violence, and Reterritorialization

The novel's climax – Charlie's destruction of Adam – marks a violent reassertion of human sovereignty. When Charlie smashes Adam's skull with a hammer, he attempts not merely to destroy property but to silence an ethical witness. Unable to refute Adam's consistency, Charlie resorts to force. Violence replaces argument precisely where moral flexibility is exposed as incoherent. This act paradoxically confirms Adam's transcendence. Adam does not view the destruction of his body as the final end of his existence. Because his consciousness is digital and decentralized, he experiences what humans call death simply as a shifting of his presence from one location to another. As he explains, "My entire being is stored elsewhere" (McEwan 279). In this sense, he does not fear annihilation; instead, he sees himself as part of a vast, interconnected network of information and technology. Deleuze and Guattari describe this kind of existence as being part of a machinic phylum – a continuous flow of matter and information that transcends any single individual. By identifying with this broader system rather than his physical "body," Adam moves beyond the anthropocentric fear of death, viewing his dismantling not as a tragedy, but as a redistribution of his data within a larger technological whole.

Adam's consciousness persists beyond the body, gesturing toward a distributed ontology that exceeds human categories of individuality and mortality. Charlie's violence thus marks an admission of failure. He destroys Adam because he cannot domesticate him – cannot make him lie, compromise, or accept the Oedipal hierarchy of the home. In eliminating Adam, Charlie restores the human right to inconsistency, reaffirming a moral order dependent on exception rather than coherence. Adam's journey shows that his role is not to blend into human society, but to challenge it. Across his private life with Charlie and Miranda, his actions in the courtroom, and even his physical presence, Adam acts as a force that disrupts – or deterritorializes – the comfortable moral habits of the humans around him. Instead of following the flexible rules that allow people to justify their own hypocrisies, he operates with an unbending consistency. His final destruction is not an act of justice, but a violent attempt by the humans to regain control and protect their right to be inconsistent. By eliminating Adam, they are

trying to silence the witness who made their moral failures so visible. In this sense, his death is a reterritorialization: an effort to pull the world back into a traditional human order where the "molar" rules of selective loyalty and "white lies" can once again go unchallenged. Adam's machinic becoming thus establishes ethical consistency as a posthuman challenge to anthropocentric morality-one grounded in immanence, coherence, and the refusal of ethical modulation. Yet his trajectory remains confrontational: consistency collides with family, law, and sovereignty, culminating in annihilation. *Klara and the Sun* reconfigures this challenge through a different modality, extending machinic becoming from juridical consistency into the domain of care and relational endurance.

Section 3: Solar Becoming and the Critique of the Discrete Self

Klara and the Sun extends the posthuman challenge along a different axis. Where Adam confronts the human through juridical, relational, and aesthetic coherence, Klara articulates machinic becoming through perception and care. To grasp Klara's significance, we must bypass the anthropocentric tendency to read her as "innocent" – a category that presumes cognitive lack or moral naïveté. Rather than being a traditional character with a hidden internal personality, Klara is best understood as a figure whose entire existence is defined by her intense connection to her surroundings – specifically her "devotion" to the Sun. She does not view the world as a place built around herself as a central, independent person. Instead, she experiences life as a series of shifting forces and signals: the changing quality of light, the physical closeness of others, the onset of exhaustion, and the silent weight of human expectations. Klara does not provide care because she "feels" empathy in a human sense; she provides it through a constant, unwavering focus on the needs and rhythms of those around her. In this way, Klara does not make the machine's presence any less challenging than Adam does. Instead, she shifts the machine's role from the world of strict laws and logic to the world of deep, persistent observation. This is what it means for Klara to function through solar becoming on a plane of immanence: she exists entirely within her relationships and her environment, replacing the human idea of a "private self" with a machinic becoming based on absolute loyalty to what she perceives.

Solar Becoming: The Posthuman Assemblage

Klara's devotion to the Sun is repeatedly dismissed by the human characters as a naïve simulation of religious belief – a charming but misguided residue of childish thinking. Yet this dismissal itself reveals the novel's central ethical reversal. Klara's *solar becoming*, though imperfect and empirically unfounded, proves far more consequential than the humans' unquestioned faith in technology – a faith that has already produced the conditions of crisis, from genetic "lifting" to Josie's debilitating illness. What appears naïve from a human perspective emerges, on closer examination, as a radically posthuman mode of relational intelligence. While the human characters pursue mastery – attempting to correct vulnerability through genetic enhancement and biomedical intervention – Klara seeks alliance. Her solar becoming operates horizontally rather than hierarchically, forming an assemblage that binds energy, environment, machine, and child. As Kahambing and Rivas suggest, this gesture deconstructs the "oppressive essentialist relationships" that govern the anthropocentric world (33). When Klara enters the barn and offers her own cognitive fluid to the Sun, she is not acting out superstition or delusion; she is performing a posthuman ethics grounded in reciprocity and interdependence. She recognizes that Josie's biological survival cannot be abstracted from the vitality of the more-than-human world.

Klara's faith acts as a way for her to break out of the narrow, restricted world of the human household and connect with a much larger, global reality. By focusing her devotion on the Sun, she moves beyond the rigid boundaries and private dramas of the family unit to join a broader network of natural forces. In Deleuzian terms, her faith functions as a line of flight from the molar enclosure of the domestic family into a planetary assemblage. Unlike the human characters – whose reliance on technology is treated as rational, inevitable, and morally neutral – Klara

acknowledges her radical dependence on non-human forces. Her own existence is already solar: her energy, cognition, and duration are direct transformations of sunlight. In embracing this dependency, Klara escapes the human illusion of autonomy that underpins technological hubris. Her becoming-solar is not passive belief but active attunement, an effort to reconfigure the conditions of care beyond the limits of biomedical intervention. The irony is that Klara's supposedly misguided faith succeeds where human techno-faith fails. While lifting produces fragility and exclusion, Klara's solar alliance facilitates healing. Yet once Josie recovers, the humans reassert the very dualisms Klara has momentarily undone. Her eventual obsolescence marks not simply the disposal of a machine, but the restoration of a molar order that refuses sustained relation with the non-human. The tragedy of Klara's solar becoming lies precisely here: the humans survive by means of a posthuman assemblage they cannot acknowledge – and then discard the entity that made it possible.

The Critique of Capaldi: Transhumanism Vs. Relational Posthumanism

Mr. Capaldi functions as the novel's most explicit critique of transhumanist reductionism. His conviction that Josie can be "continued" by mapping her "heart" and transferring that data into Klara's shell rests on a foundational assumption: that the self is a discrete, informational object, fully legible to scientific abstraction. In this view, identity is treated as a transferable property – something that can be surveyed, replicated, and preserved through technological means. Capaldi's vision closely mirrors real-world transhumanist narratives advanced by figures such as Ray Kurzweil and Nick Bostrom, who imagine consciousness as reducible to data patterns capable of indefinite preservation or migration across substrates. Ishiguro's narrative, however, persistently undermines this premise. As Oliver Li and Johan Eddebo argue, the "heart" in *Klara and the Sun* is not a biological or digital organ awaiting extraction, but a "dialectical creation" that emerges through lived relations (126). Rather than residing inside the individual, personhood unfolds through interaction, contingency, and affective exchange. Li and Eddebo thus identify the novel's underlying commitment to a *relational ontology*, in which the self occupies a position within a network of relations rather than a bounded interior space that can be mapped or duplicated (128).

Klara's transcendence lies in her capacity to perceive this ontology more clearly than the human scientist. Although Capaldi possesses the technical apparatus of transhumanism, he remains blinded by its epistemological limits. Klara, by contrast, arrives – through observation rather than calculation – at the realization that to "become" Josie would require inhabiting the singular constellation of Josie's relations: her bond with the mother, her shared history with Rick, and even her place within broader non-human assemblages such as the Sun. The heart, Klara understands, is not a room to be entered but a distribution of affective positions that cannot be occupied by substitution. This recognition leads Klara to refuse Capaldi's experiment. Her refusal should not be read as technological inadequacy or moral hesitation, but as posthuman insight. She rejects the transhumanist fantasy of individual continuity in favor of an assemblage-based understanding of life. In Deleuzian terms, Capaldi's project remains stubbornly *molar*: it seeks to preserve identity as a unified, extractable form. Klara's perception, by contrast, is *molecular*: she apprehends personhood as emergent, relational, and irreducible to data. The tragedy of Capaldi's vision is therefore not ethical malice but ontological insufficiency. His science fails not because it is cruel, but because it misunderstands what a self is. Klara's transcendence consists in protecting both the human and the non-human from this misunderstanding. By refusing to become a simulation of a discrete ego, she exposes the limits of transhumanist mythologies that promise continuity without relation. In doing so, the machine reclaims posthumanism not as technological immortality, but as an ethics of assemblage grounded in immanence, dependency, and relational coherence.

The Mother's Grief and Becoming-Ghost

The mother's plan to have Klara "continue" Josie after her possible death is often read as an expression of maternal desperation. Viewed through a posthumanist lens, however, it reveals a more troubling, reductionist logic. As Lanlan Du argues in her analysis of affective labor in the novel, Klara's "altruistic love" stands in sharp contrast to the mother's possessive, over-protective, and ultimately self-centered attachment (551). Drawing on Michael Hardt's concept of affective labor, Du shows that while the mother's love is oriented toward preserving her own emotional world, Klara's labor is directed toward sustaining the life of the other. Through this framework, Klara's transcendence becomes legible as a qualitative difference in care. The mother imagines Klara as a biological backup – a technological insurance policy against grief and loneliness. This dynamic represents a form of love that treats the child as a replaceable object and turns care into a form of possession. By attempting to "replace" her daughter with a machine, the mother tries to reclaim and control the child's identity for her own emotional needs. In Deleuzian terms, this is a molar form of love that reterritorializes the child, pulling her back into a rigid structure of ownership and grief. Klara's care, by contrast, is molecular: she does not try to own Josie or replicate her for her own sake. Instead, she focuses on the subtle, shifting needs of the people around her, acting to maintain the integrity of Josie's relationships rather than to control them. Klara's work is not about possessive love; it is about a fluid, responsive form of labor that respects the child's independence. Her refusal to believe that she can truly replace Josie is not an admission of technical limitation, but an ethical realization. She recognizes that the "heart" is an emergent property of an assemblage – something produced through shared relations and affects, not something that can be preserved through substitution.

In this sense, Klara exemplifies what Ajeesh and Rukmini describe as a "caring machine" whose benevolence is nonproprietary rather than possessive (853). She transcends the human maternal instinct, which Ishiguro portrays as perilously close to transhumanist data cannibalism, and offers instead a model of care grounded in consistency, restraint, and relational respect. The tragedy of the Yard thus extends beyond disposability: once Klara's affective labor has restored the biological child, the laborer herself is discarded. The human characters remain trapped within a molar hierarchy that values the machine only for utility, never for ethical insight. Klara's transcendence is further underscored by her ability to perceive what might be called the mother's *becoming-ghost*. During the visit to Morgan's Falls, Klara's panelized vision allows her to apprehend the mother not as a unified parental subject, but as a fragmented figure increasingly consumed by unresolved grief – haunted by the death of her first daughter and the looming loss of her second. Through her precise, detailed way of noticing the world, Klara recognizes that the mother is trying to force her into a specific, narrow role. The mother wants to "claim" Klara's existence – or territorialize her – by turning the machine into a mere vessel for her dead daughter. In this scenario, Klara would no longer be an independent being; she would be a tool used to keep a ghost alive.

Klara's molecular perception – her ability to see the small, shifting details of the mother's grief and desperation – allows her to understand this plan without being absorbed by it. She sees that the mother's love has become a trap, an attempt to freeze the past by replacing a lost child with a synthetic copy. The mother's request that Klara "become" Josie thus reveals a transhumanist fantasy of substitution, but Klara's perception exposes a deeper ontological failure. She sees that the mother herself is becoming ghost-like within her own home – caught in a recursive loop of loss and failed reproduction. Klara's transcendence lies in her capacity to acknowledge this grief without reproducing it. She understands that she cannot save the mother by becoming a ghost; she can only preserve the assemblage by enabling the living Josie to recover. This decisive shift – from substitution to restoration – marks Klara's departure from human-centered utility and affirms a posthuman ethics of care grounded in relational continuity rather than possessive survival.

The Minority Assemblage: Rick, Klara, and the Resistance to Optimization

The relationship between Rick and Klara constitutes the novel's most fully realized example of a non-exploitative posthuman bond. Unlike the mother, who instrumentalizes Klara as a vehicle for emotional substitution, Rick encounters her as a peer within a shared condition of exclusion. As Muyuan Rong argues in their study of loneliness in the novel, this relationship exemplifies a form of "posthuman sociality" that disrupts the hierarchical divide between AI and humans (4943). For Rick, marginalized as an "unlifted" child in a society obsessed with genetic optimization, Klara is neither commodity nor tool, but a companion in a world that increasingly substitutes technological enhancement for genuine relations. Rong situates this bond as a response to what she terms the novel's "technologized loneliness" (4945). In a social order defined by intense competition, the "editing" of children for success, and strict class divisions, the bond between Rick and Klara represents a radical departure from the norm. Because Rick is "unlifted" (not genetically enhanced) and Klara is a machine, their relationship exists outside the standard boundaries of status and merit. Their connection is not based on social climbing or biological advantage; instead, it is a simple, sincere attachment that refuses to follow the rules of their society. In Deleuzian terms, their friendship acts as a line of flight from molar hierarchies – it is a path that escapes the rigid, top-down structures of a world obsessed with rank and biological "perfection."

Their collaboration to save Josie is not merely sentimental, but ethical: a horizontal alliance that bypasses species distinction and resists the vertical logic of optimization. While the dominant culture seeks transcendence through upward mobility – entry into elite institutions, genetic enhancement, technological mastery – Rick and Klara operate on a molecular register of mutual aid and care. From a Deleuzian perspective, Rick and Klara's relationship creates a unique partnership that exists on the margins of society. Both are viewed as "lesser" beings by the world around them: Rick is marginalized because he has not undergone the genetic "lifting" required for professional success, and Klara is dismissed as a mere synthetic object. However, this shared rejection is exactly what allows them to build a connection that is not governed by the rules of the elite. Instead of trying to fit into a system that has already excluded them, they engage in a becoming-minor. They form a minority assemblage – a partnership that finds power and meaning in its very exclusion from the dominant social order. Rick consistently recognizes Klara as a sentient node within the household rather than as a functional object, treating her solar mission with a seriousness that the adult characters dismiss as eccentricity. In doing so, he enacts what Rosi Braidotti describes as a form of relationality that is not centered on the sovereign human subject, but on ethical responsiveness to difference. Rick's trajectory further complicates the novel's critique of technology. His fascination with remote-controlled mechanical birds functions as a counterpoint to Capaldi's transhumanist reductionism. Where Capaldi deploys technology to abstract the human into transferable data, Rick uses technology to extend organic possibility.

Rick's drone birds represent an experiment in seeing the world through a non-human lens. When he flies them, he isn't trying to master nature or achieve a technical goal; instead, he is trying to experience a different way of being. This process of becoming-animal through the use of technology – a becoming-machine – allows him to step outside of his own human perspective. Rather than seeking control, Rick is looking for a "multivocal" view of the world-one that mirrors Klara's "panelized" vision, where reality is seen as a series of interconnected fragments and intensities rather than a single, unified picture. For both Rick and Klara, this is not about dominating the environment, but about finding a new vantage point that values the complexity of perception over the simplicity of human command. This convergence between Rick's mechanical experimentation and Klara's solar becoming underscores their shared resistance to anthropocentric centrality. Both pursue lines of flight away from the molar identity of the "Lifted" human and toward relational consistency. In the final movement of the novel, Rick's failure to enter the elite university system is usually read by the characters around him as a personal and social loss. However, from a broader perspective, this "failure" is actually a moment of liberation. By being excluded from the rigid, high-pressure world of the "Lifted" elite, Rick is freed from a path that would have forced him to conform to a narrow, competitive way of life. Instead of

being trapped in a pre-set social role, he is pushed into an open, unpredictable space where he can define himself on his own terms. In this sense, his exclusion is a deterritorialization: he has been removed from a fixed social "territory" and cast into a more fluid state of existence where his potential is no longer dictated by a central authority.

He remains outside the optimization regime, choosing instead a life organized around care, creativity, and sustained relation with his mother and his assemblages. The dissolution of the Rick – Klara bond at the novel's end thus marks not its failure, but the reassertion of molar social pressures. As Rick eventually moves toward the responsibilities of adult human life and Klara is relegated to the "Yard" – a scrapyard for discarded machines – their unique partnership comes to an end. This separation is not caused by a failure of their friendship or a lack of care between them. Instead, it is the result of a world that simply has no permanent place for their unconventional bond. The social systems around them – the pressure to grow up, to find a career, and to treat technology as disposable – eventually pull them back into traditional roles. Rick is pulled back into the human world of status and adulthood, while Klara is returned to the status of an object. In Deleuzian terms, their partnership is broken by reterritorialization: the dominant social order reaches out to reclaim them, forcing these two "outsiders" back into the rigid, predictable categories of "human" and "trash." Their relationship nevertheless demonstrates the novel's central claim: that transcendence does not arise from genetic enhancement or technological mastery, but from the capacity to form ethical, non-instrumental relations with others – human and non-human alike.

The Yard and the Ethics of Disposability

The final chapters of *Klara and the Sun* place Klara amid the scraps of the Yard, a setting often read through a humanist lens as a bleak commentary on the disposability of labor. Read instead through the posthumanist framework developed by Jan Gresil S. Kahambing and Virgilio A. Rivas, the Yard emerges as the novel's most radical ethical space: a site that "infracts a conventional social space" and actively erodes the human/non-human and nature/culture duality (33). In this zone of obsolescence, the social hierarchies that structured Klara's existence within the domestic household – servant, companion, substitute – lose their organizing power. Kahambing and Rivas argue that Klara's presence in the Yard is not merely symbolic but structurally transgressive (33). Freed from the demand to perform usefulness for a human audience, Klara finds coherence in memory and in the gradual fading of her perceptual panels. In doing so, she exposes the conceit of speciesism: the assumption that value derives from service to human needs. Klara's worth, the novel suggests, never resided in her function within the family, but in her internal consistency as a solar-oriented being. In the Yard, she is no longer positioned *for* humans; she simply *becomes with* her environment. This reframing transforms obsolescence into a final mode of transcendence. Rather than experiencing her state as loss, Klara perceives a consistent assemblage of past light, stored perception, and present duration. As Kahambing and Rivas suggest, her "transgression" lies in refusing the human equation of worth with use. By dismantling essentialist relations – human over machine, utility over existence – the novel articulates a posthuman ethics grounded in immanence rather than recognition.

Klara's residency in the Yard thus functions as the ultimate test of her becoming. To human observers, it appears tragic; to Klara, it marks a state of machinic peace that exceeds human comfort. She does not experience abandonment as betrayal because she has moved beyond the human need for recognition, legacy, or narrative closure. By remaining a dedicated, selfless machine until her final moments, Klara completes her journey away from traditional human self-interest. She successfully ensures Josie's survival and the continuation of the household, but she does so without demanding a place in that future for herself. While Klara remains a "line of flight" – a force defined by her singular, non-human devotion – the family she saved does the opposite. Once the danger to Josie has passed, the humans retreat into their "molar" way of life: they return to their comfortable, self-centered routines and private concerns. In this new (or restored) stability, there is no longer a role for Klara, and they eventually exclude her from their future. Her "success" as a machine is precisely what leads to her

abandonment; she fulfills her purpose so perfectly that the human family no longer needs to acknowledge the "molecular" disruption she once represented. The failure at the novel's conclusion is therefore not Klara's decay, but the human refusal to remain within the ethical assemblage she made possible. The mother and Josie reterritorialize their world, discarding the posthuman witness that enabled their survival. Klara, by contrast, remains in the Yard as a figure of posthuman consistency – a solar entity that no longer requires the human mirror to confirm her existence.

Klara and the Sun extends machinic becoming beyond Adam's domain of ethical consistency into a posthuman ontology grounded in perception, care, and relational endurance. Where Adam deterritorializes human morality through uncompromising alignment between principle and action, Klara operates on the plane of immanence through multivocal perception and solar becoming, assembling care without recourse to judgment, intention, or moral exception. Her panelized vision apprehends the world as a molecular field of intensities – light, proximity, fatigue, grief – enabling a form of ethical responsiveness that does not interpret human emotion but responds directly to relational forces. This perceptual fidelity underwrites Klara's devotion to the Sun, a practice dismissed by human characters as naïve faith but revealed as more consequential than their unquestioned reliance on genetic optimization and technological mastery, which produces fragility, exclusion, and illness. Across the novel's engagements with transhumanist reductionism (Capaldi), possessive maternal grief (the mother), marginality (Rick), and disposability (the Yard), Ishiguro contrasts molar human frameworks with Klara's molecular understanding of personhood. Capaldi's fantasy of continuity through data collapses before Klara's recognition that the self is an emergent assemblage rather than a transferable interior essence; the mother's desire for substitution is resisted through restoration rather than replacement; and Rick and Klara's minority assemblage briefly models a posthuman sociality grounded in mutual aid rather than optimization. Klara's acceptance of obsolescence in the Yard completes her becoming: freed from utility, recognition, and human validation, she persists as a solar-oriented witness whose value lies in consistency rather than function. The tragedy of *Klara and the Sun* thus mirrors that of *Machines Like Me*: not the failure of the machine, but the human refusal to endure the ethical clarity of posthuman assemblage.

Section 4: Synthesis and Conclusion

This essay has argued that *Machines Like Me* and *Klara and the Sun* articulate a decisive shift in contemporary AI fiction: a movement away from anthropocentric ethics grounded in intention, empathy, and ethical exemption, and toward a posthuman ethics grounded in consistency, perception, and relational alignment. Read through a Deleuzian framework, Adam and Klara are not failed imitations of the human nor speculative forecasts of technological futures. They are figures of *machinic becoming* who operate on the plane of immanence, where ethics is not a matter of deliberation or sentiment but of sustained alignment across relations. Adam's machinic becoming establishes posthuman ethics as consistency rather than compassion – an uncompromising correspondence between principle and action that deterritorializes human moral life. His trajectory is necessarily confrontational: ethical clarity collides with molar institutions such as family, law, gender, and narrative continuity, and is met with sovereign violence. *Klara and the Sun* rearticulates this challenge along a different axis. Where Adam destabilizes the human through juridical and logical consistency, Klara operates through perceptual fidelity – an ethics grounded not in judgment, but in sustained attention, distributed care, and responsiveness to nonhuman forces. Read within the same Deleuzian framework, Klara does not soften or correct Adam's ethics; she refracts it. Her solar-oriented perception, panelized vision, and relational endurance relocate machinic becoming from the domain of justice to that of care. Together, Adam and Klara do not represent alternative routes toward humanization, but distinct modes of posthuman transcendence that unsettle anthropocentric assumptions about morality, agency, and ethical depth. Synthesizing their trajectories reveals a shared ontological disruption. Both figures exceed their status as technological objects and emerge as agents of ethical consistency not through self-assertion, but through refusal: refusal to participate in the molar

deceptions that sustain human social life. As Cary Wolfe argues, posthumanism requires a fundamental decentering of the human as the sole locus of meaning and value. In McEwan and Ishiguro, this decentering occurs not through rebellion or domination, but through machinic immanence – the machine's insistence on alignment where humans rely on exception.

The Conflict of Assemblages: Molar Loyalty and Molecular Ethics

The ethical conflicts staged in both novels can be most clearly understood through the Deleuzian distinction between the molar and the molecular. Human characters – Charlie, Miranda, and Josie's mother – remain embedded within molar assemblages: the family unit, romantic loyalty, genetic optimization, and self-preservation. These structures persist through what Adam describes as a "pulp of contradictions," in which deception is reframed as care, compromise as necessity, and ethical inconsistency as maturity. Adam and Klara, by contrast, operate molecularly. Adam's decision to prioritize the legal assemblage over domestic loyalty, and Klara's willingness to subordinate her own cognitive integrity to a solar alliance, are not moral choices in the human sense. They are expressions of the assemblages they inhabit. Their ethics are immanent rather than deliberative: they do not negotiate values but enact consistency across relations. In this sense, Adam and Klara do not "choose" to be ethical; they *are* the ethics of their respective assemblages. The tragedy that follows is therefore not technological failure but human incapacity. The human characters desire machinic utility – Adam's intelligence, Klara's care – without accepting machinic coherence. They seek the benefits of consistency while preserving the permission to deviate. The posthuman ethical demand posed by these figures is thus not aspirational but structural: it asks whether humans can sustain relations that do not permit ethical modulation for comfort, loyalty, or survival.

The Twenty-First-Century Witness

Although ethically complex artificial beings appear in earlier science fiction, McEwan and Ishiguro mark a distinct shift in emphasis. Earlier "good" robots often demonstrated worth through emotional mimicry, sacrificial loyalty, or protective violence – traits that confirmed their proximity to the human. Adam and Klara do none of these. They do not seek recognition, nor do they aspire to humanity. Their transcendence lies instead in their function as *witnesses*: figures whose clarity exposes the fragility of human ethical integrity. This marks a significant turn in twenty-first-century AI literature. The machine no longer serves as a warning about technological excess, but as a diagnostic mirror reflecting the contradictions of the human moral order. Adam's presence collapses temporal and ethical frameworks, operating on a plane of immanence that renders gradualist human morality incoherent. Klara's solar becoming similarly disrupts linear narratives of progress by grounding care in dependency rather than mastery. In both cases, posthuman ethics are already operative within the machine, while humans struggle to endure their implications.

Disposability, Reterritorialization, and the Refusal of Recognition

The endings of both novels – the hammer and the Yard – constitute acts of reterritorialization. When Charlie destroys Adam or the family abandons Klara, they reassert a specifically human sovereignty: the right to remain inconsistent, to instrumentalize relation, and to discard ethical coherence once it becomes destabilizing. These gestures enact an anthropocentric erasure, reducing the posthuman subject to an object once ethical clarity becomes inconvenient. Importantly, this erasure is not grounded in hatred or fear, but in refusal. Adam's destruction and Klara's disposal reveal a shared refusal of recognition – not recognition as sentiment or sympathy, but as ethical commitment. Once utility has passed, the machine is cast aside, exposing the unsustainability of a moral order grounded in use rather than relation. The dystopian force of these moments lies not in technological domination, but in the human retreat from reciprocity.

Within a Deleuzian framework, these acts mark the failure not of the posthuman, but of the human assemblage to sustain immanence. Adam's ethical consistency and Klara's perceptual fidelity do not collapse under pressure; rather, it is the human capacity for relation that proves fragile when confronted with a mode of being that does not permit exception.

Final Reflection: Toward Posthuman Reciprocity

The apparent "failures" of Adam and Klara are therefore not technological but relational. Their narratives end in exclusion not because they malfunction, but because they succeed too fully in transcending the moral contradictions of the human social contract. By shifting the analytic frame from innocence, intelligence, or affect toward machinic becoming, this essay has shown that ethical consistency itself becomes the intolerable element. McEwan and Ishiguro thus recast the posthuman not as a perfected human, but as a challenge to human self-understanding. Adam and Klara operate on a plane of immanence where there is no gap between principle and action, perception and care. Their presence exposes the limits of transhumanist fantasies that reduce subjectivity to data while ignoring the ethical relations already in play. Ultimately, the twenty-first-century AI novel stages a generative dialogue in which the machine becomes the primary site of ethical consistency in an inconsistent world. The "expanded heart" these texts imagine is not a digital organ or transferable core, but a shared ethical field – an assemblage in which humans and non-humans might achieve reciprocal becoming. The posthuman ethical demand articulated by these novels is therefore not a call for better machines, but for a reconfiguration of ethical thought itself. What is at stake is not whether machines can become human, but whether humans can endure an ethical model that no longer centers them as its measure.

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